

COOKING UP A STORM The scene inside the Akshaya Patra centralised kitchen in Chikkajala, Bengaluru

across India, which together ensure that 2.35 million children in over 23,000 government schools have their tummies full on a daily basis. Its vision: "No child in India shall be deprived of education because of hunger." That makes it a larger force for good.

We have 9,000 'hunger warriors' in Akshaya Patra, so called because they solve the problem of classroom hunger," says Shridhar Venkat, CEO of Akshaya Patra Foundation (APF). The first NGO to partner with the government midday meal programme, now called PM Poshan, APF started by feeding 1,500 children from five schools in Bengaluru in 2000. In due course, it built the world's largest mega-kitchen in Hubballi in Karnataka, serving 150,000 meals a day, and, over a quarter century, followed up with centralised kitchens across 16 states and three Union territories. It now runs the world's largest school meal programme by a non-profit.

CEOSPEAK

"For one lakh children, we needed two lakh rotis a day. We adapted a papad-making machine and worked with a manufacturer to re-engineer it. This kind of innovative scaling is central to Akshaya Patra's model"

CHANCHALAPATHI DASA
Co-founder & Vice Chairman

The goal is to provide a midday meal to three million children and an additional three million servings of morning nutrition (ready-to-eat healthy snacks) daily by 2030. Currently, it provides 800,000 servings of morning nutrition. Menus change day to day and across regions, from *dal-dhokli* in Gujarat to *pitha* in Assam, keeping in mind the local flavour. If rice is the staple in the South, machines that can churn out 40,000 rotis an hour cater to the northern palate.

A zero-debt organisation, roughly 55 per cent of the cost of running the programme comes from the government through cash and grain subsidy; APF raises the remainder from corporate and individual donors. However, as Venkat puts it, fund-raising is like "being on a treadmill" constantly. To reach its target of six million servings, the non-profit will require Rs 2,500 crore a year, a nearly three-fold jump from total expenditure of Rs 867 crore in FY25. But money is one thing. "What really matters is the transformation it brings in the lives of children," says Venkat. And that starts with a full stomach. ■